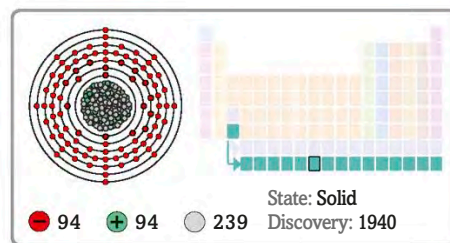


94
Pu

Plutonium



Uraninite

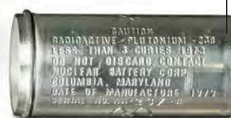


Hardly any plutonium exists in nature: most of it has decayed into other elements over time.

It was discovered during the development of nuclear bombs in World War II. Today, plutonium is used mostly as a nuclear fuel.

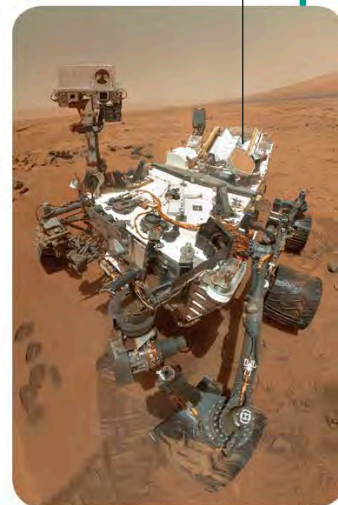
This ore contains trace amounts of plutonium.

This plutonium battery was used in early pacemakers.



1970's pacemaker battery

This Martian rover uses the heat given off by a supply of plutonium to generate electrical power.

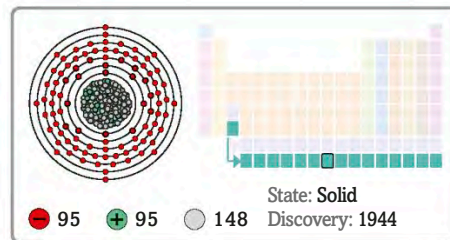


Curiosity Rover

Actinides

95
Am

Americium



Smoke detector component



This metallic element is not found in nature. Instead, it is produced inside nuclear reactors when uranium or plutonium atoms are bombarded with neutrons. Remarkably, americium is the most common radioactive element used in the home. Radioactivity emitted by americium atoms causes the air inside **smoke detectors** to conduct electricity. When smoke disrupts the electric current, an alarm goes off.

This smoke detector contains tiny, harmless quantities of americium.